

Φιλόδαμος ὁ Σκαρφεύς

The Paean to Dionysus by Philodamus of Scarpheia

eul_aid: hdk

Period: [Κλασική](#) [Classical](#)

Dialect: [Ἀττική](#) [Attic](#)

Domain: [Ποίησης](#) [Poetry](#)

Format: [Ἑμμετρος](#) [Verse](#)

Philodamus of Scarpheia was a lyric poet active in the mid-to-late 4th century BCE. His life is known from a single surviving paean to Dionysus, inscribed on stone at Delphi. The inscription records that he was the son of Mnesieus from Scarpheia in Locris and that he and his brothers were granted proxenia by the Delphic Amphictyony, which commissioned the hymn for performance at the Theoxenia festival. This situates him as a poet of standing working on official Panhellenic religious commissions during a period of political turmoil involving Philip II of Macedon.

His only known work is the Paean to Dionysus, preserved in its complete form on the Delphi inscription. Philodamus's significance stems from the rare survival of his complete poem, a direct example of 4th-century BCE cult song. The work provides valuable evidence for the continued performance of lyric poetry in religious ritual, the worship of Dionysus at Delphi, and the political use of poetry by bodies like the Amphictyony. The inscription also serves as a document for Delphic institutions and the practice of proxenia.

Works (1)

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